



A PRABHAKAR RAO

ULTRA TECH: Singh with his staff

CENTRE FOR CELLULAR AND MOLECULAR BIOLOGY, HYDERABAD

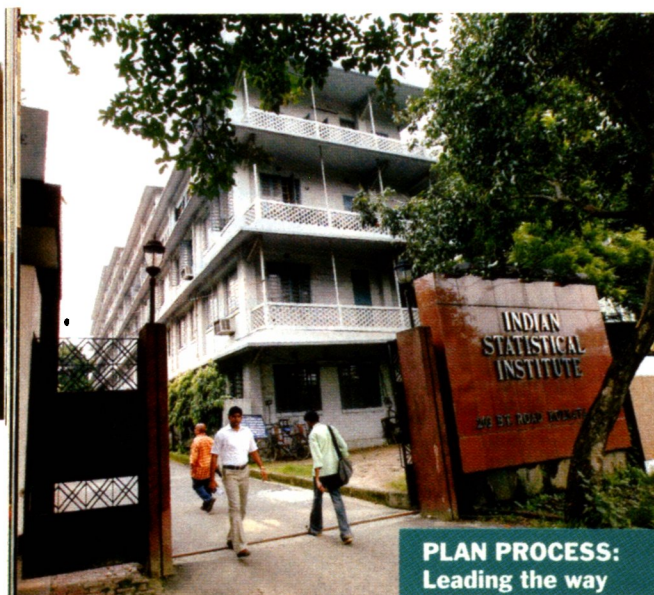
CODE CRACKER

Founded in only 1977, the Centre for Cellular and Molecular Biology (CCMB) is engaged in multi-disciplinary initiatives in molecular and cell biology round the clock. As CCMB Director Lalji Singh says, "We are open 24x7 so that researchers have the freedom to access instrumentation and other facilities, focus on work instead of attendance and be among the leaders in the post human genome sequence era since 1998." The advent of DNA fingerprinting means that it has to provide evidence in paternity disputes, exchange of babies in maternity wards, identify missing children, and give evidence in murder and rape cases. The Rajiv Gandhi assassination case was its most crucial. Apart from forensics, it is involved in the ambitious study of genetic diversity among Indian tribals along with the Anthropological Survey of India. Similarly, the DNA typing of animals is underway in order to conserve endangered species.

by Amarnath K. Menon

SAVING CELLS

The centre has used the blood samples of 100 tribes and 11,000 individuals to develop transformed cell lines, which have been preserved for posterity. It hopes to protect vanishing tribes from extinction.



PLAN PROCESS: Leading the way

SUBIR HALDER

INDIAN STATISTICAL INSTITUTE, KOLKATA

CRUNCHING NUMBERS

Set up with a humble budget of Rs 238 in 1931, the Indian Statistical Institute (ISI) has now grown to 250 faculty members, 1,000 support staff with 150 students and a budget of over Rs 60 crore. With its formation on December 17 in a meeting between P.C. Mahalanobis, P. N. Banerjee and N.R. Sen in a small room in the Presidency College, Kolkata, research in statistics in India took a formal turn. Initially it functioned from there itself and later, a portion

from Mahalanobis' residence but now it has three campuses, one across 30 acre in Kolkata. ISI conducts research in different fields of science where statistics plays the role of the unifier. As ISI Director Sankar K. Pal says, "Our main focus is to encourage research; teaching is only a by-product." Declared an institution of national importance in 1959, the ISI even made the blueprint of the second five year plan.

by Samik Biswas